



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Historical epic

DIRECTOR

D. W. Griffith

WRITERS

D. W. Griffith, Anita Loos

STARS

Vera Lewis, Ralph Lewis, Constance Talmadge, Lillian Gish, Mae Marsh, Robert Harron

BEFORE

1914 Italian director Giovanni Pastrone makes *Cabiria*, an early feature-length epic.

1915 Griffith's *The Birth of a Nation* is the first US feature movie, but sparks controversy with its racist content.

AFTER

1931 Griffith's final movie, *The Struggle* (his second sound feature), is a box-office failure. It is a semiautobiographical tale of a battle with alcoholism.

OUT OF THE CRADLE ENDLESSLY ROCKING

INTOLERANCE / 1916

One of the most influential movies ever made, *Intolerance* is truly epic in its scope, with elaborate sets and countless extras. It was not the first movie to use techniques such as camera tracking and close-ups, but director D. W. Griffith used them with such mastery that many regard him as the father of modern moviemaking.

The movie was born in controversy. Griffith's previous movie in 1915, *The Clansman*, came to be called *The Birth of a Nation* and was the first full-length feature movie made in the US. Its innovative techniques foreshadowed

those used in *Intolerance*. It was a hit, but was condemned by many for its overt racism, glorifying slavery and the Ku Klux Klan.

Its commercial success, however, bankrolled the cast of thousands required to make *Intolerance*, which lost as much at the box office as *The Clansman* had made. Some critics describe *Intolerance* as an apology for the earlier movie, but there is nothing apologetic in its ambition and scale.

Four-part drama

Four stories of intolerance, spanning three millennia, interweave through the movie, each with a different



D. W. Griffith Director

Born on a farm in Kentucky in 1875, David Llewelyn Wark Griffith was 10

when his father died, leaving the family in poverty. After several years of stage work, he got an acting job for a movie company in 1908, and was soon making his own movies, some of the first ever made in Hollywood. He set up his own company to make

The Birth of a Nation, whose racism caused protests and riots. Griffith made about 500 movies in total, but his career entered into a downward spiral after *Intolerance*. He died in 1948.

Key movies

1909 *A Corner of Wheat*
1915 *The Birth of a Nation*
1916 *Intolerance*
1919 *Broken Blossoms*